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A family shattered by a catastrophic injury on the field.



JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

Did it have to be?

STORY BY BOB HOHLER | GLOBE STAFF

A reluctant football mom rushed to her fallen son. He lay motionless in the wet grass, emergency responders hovering around him. She heard a voice pleading, “Rohan, wake up, your mom’s here.” Then nothing.

Moments earlier, 15-year-old Rohan Shukla had seized an opportunity to shine on the field. A sophomore starting only his second varsity game for Sharon High School, he made an inspiring play, leaping in the cold morning mist last Thanksgiving to deflect a pass intended for a receiver from Oliver Ames High School, Sharon’s visiting rival from Easton. Fans cheered, and in that moment during the final game of the 2024 season, Rohan signaled that he belonged — that he would be part of Sharon’s football future.

What no one seemed to notice was that the play ended with Rohan’s helmeted skull crashing to the ground. He gripped a teammate’s hand to rise, then walked slowly to the sideline, weaker by the step.

On the bench, he told a teammate, “I have a headache.”

He went limp. Then he collapsed.

As he lay unconscious on his back, his eyes rolled back and his mouth foaming, no one knew the exact nature of Rohan’s condition. There was confusion

FOOTBALL, Page C12



Rohan Shukla’s mother, Deepika Talukdar, joined the Sharon High School sophomore in his room at Spaulding Rehabilitation Hospital.

Wear plover attire

Sunday: Cooler, rain late. High 65-70, low 48-53.
Monday: More showers. Complete report, **A24**.

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All-Scholastics

The Globe profiles standout performers in swimming, hockey, basketball, indoor track, and other winter sports.

Warren Buffett revealed he will retire from Berkshire Hathaway at the end of the year. **A8**.

Sovereignty outdueled the favorite, Journalism, down the stretch to take the Kentucky Derby. **C3**.

As tax fight looms, Republicans have a tricky sales pitch to make

By Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — When President Trump signed a sweeping tax cut package into law at the White House in 2017, he didn’t hesitate when a reporter asked how he and Republicans planned to sell it to the public.

“I don’t think we’re going to have to do much selling,” Trump said. “But I think come February, when they open their checks and they see — ‘Wow, what

happened? I have a lot more money in here’ — I think that’s really going to be something very special.”

Eight years later, the top legislative priority for the president and his party is getting a new tax cut bill into law. But this time around, it won’t be such a simple sell. That’s because their primary task at hand is not to deliver a new suite of tax breaks; rather, it’s to extend the 2017 cuts before they expire at the end

TAXES, Page A13

At MIT, plotting a way past Trump

Leaders discuss when to be pragmatic, how to resist in face of big cuts

By Hilary Burns
GLOBE STAFF

The unrelenting high-velocity attacks from the Trump administration have forced leaders of the nation’s premier universities to navigate an extraordinary and bruising balancing act, choosing when to take a stand in the face of continued threats while trying to mitigate the loss of federal funding.

Among the schools where that intense drama is playing out is the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, where the sobering realities of the administration’s funding cuts were discussed at a meeting convened by senior leaders in April.

Under one scenario presented at that meeting by treasurer Glen Shor, MIT risks losing the equivalent of 23 percent of revenues for its central budget, according to a recording of the presentation to school staff obtained by the Globe.

“Unfortunately, we should expect a prolonged period of challenge,” MIT president Sally Kornbluth told staff, according to the recording. “We really have to balance things. And I have to say, I feel a grave responsibility to you all . . . to ensure the livelihoods of this community and to make sure that we can continue to function. I need to balance all of these goals that are, again, often in great tension

MIT, Page A14

A fleeting bounty for weed sellers

Industry struggles amid oversupply, money woes

By Diti Kohli
GLOBE STAFF

When Marco and Amanda Aranzullo launched the Euphorium Dispensary, they had little more than “our savings and a vision.”

But that money went quickly as their aspirations ran into a hard reality. The couple lost \$85,000 to a construction dispute, switched the site of the store to Holyoke from Northampton, and spent their last dollars on costly insurance. Their experience was typical for new cannabis businesses in Massachusetts: lengthy, exhausting, and expensive.

Though the dispensary only opened in July, the Aranzullos already need money to keep operating and pay the \$30,000 fee to renew Euphorium’s three cannabis licenses. And so they now wonder: Is it worth it?

“It’s going to come to the point where it might be bet-

MARIJUANA, Page A16

Nationally \$6B

Approximate debt owed by marijuana businesses that is set to mature soon

Less than **1 in 3** of all marijuana ventures turn a profit



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